

FIRST WEEK PROJECT

Digital Passport

Build Your Academic Portfolio

Activity idea for the first week of school

Main objective: replace the old portfolio template with a more current activity that also works as an academic icebreaker and leaves students with a site they can use throughout the school year.

The proposal is to create the portfolio in Canva Websites, but without using AI tools yet. The focus of this first activity is digital identity, information organization, design, and navigation.

1. Why change the activity?

The old portfolio served an important purpose: from the beginning of the year, students prepared a space where they could collect projects from all of their classes.

The problem is that building it in Slides now feels more like creating a presentation than a digital portfolio, while other traditional website options can feel outdated to students.

Using AI to generate the site is also not ideal during the first week because AI deserves to be taught as a tool with purpose, boundaries, and good practices - not simply as a shortcut for building the page.

The new idea

Turn the portfolio setup into a project called Digital Passport: Build Your Academic Portfolio.

Students create their own academic website while completing a short activity that helps the teacher get to know them, observe their digital skills, and introduce basic design principles.

What students practice without using AI

- Digital identity and personal presentation.
- Information organization.
- Visual hierarchy and readability.
- Navigation between pages or sections.
- Responsible selection of images and personal information.
- Publishing and testing a website.
- Introductory UI/UX concepts in a simple, practical way.

2. Site structure

SECTION	CONTENT
HOME	Name, grade, an appropriate avatar/icon or image, interests, three things about themselves, and one learning goal for the year.
MY TECH STORY	A short timeline about their relationship with technology.
MY CLASSES	A section or page for each class, prepared for adding projects throughout the year.

3. The central activity: My Tech Story

This part keeps the first week from feeling like pure setup. Students build a short personal story about their relationship with technology.

Suggested prompts:

1. First device I remember
2. First game or app I remember using
3. Something technology helped me learn
4. Technology I use every day
5. Technology I want to learn this year

Teacher benefit: without giving a formal diagnostic test, this activity lets you observe how students write, organize content, work with images, links, layouts, and publishing, and what kinds of technology experiences they bring to the course.

4. Prepare the class pages

The My Classes section should be functional by the end of the first week, even if it does not contain projects yet. Each class can simply have a heading and a placeholder.

Projects and work from the 2026-2027 school year will be added here.

Throughout the year, students return to the same site and add evidence, photos, files, reflections, videos, links, or final products from their different classes.

5. Usability Test

Before considering the portfolio finished, each student shares the link with a classmate. The classmate has approximately two minutes to locate specific information.

- What does this person want to learn this year?
- What is one of their interests?
- Where would you find a Science project?

Rule: if the classmate cannot find something quickly, the site owner must improve the navigation, headings, or organization. This naturally introduces the idea that good design should not only look good - it should also be easy to use.

6. Activity rules

- No AI may be used to generate text, designs, images, or site structure during this activity.
- Regular templates, icons, shapes, colors, appropriate images, and fonts are allowed.
- Students must make their own design and organization decisions.
- Do not include private or sensitive information.
- The site must have clear navigation and a working published link.

7. What to evaluate

It is better to evaluate functionality and design decisions rather than who creates the prettiest page. This reduces the advantage of students who already know Canva or have more visual design experience.

CRITERION	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Navigation works	The user can move between sections without getting confused.
Information is organized	Content is placed in the correct section.
Text is readable	Appropriate text size, contrast, and amount of text.
Design is consistent	Colors, fonts, and overall style are reasonably consistent.
Required sections are complete	Home, My Tech Story, and My Classes are prepared.
Published link works	The site opens and can be reviewed correctly.
Digital identity is appropriate	The student does not publish unnecessarily private information and maintains an appropriate school tone.

8. Possible schedule across 2-3 classes

SESSION	FOCUS
Class 1	Introduce Digital Passport, show the required structure, create Home, and begin My Tech Story.
Class 2	Finish My Tech Story, create My Classes, and review navigation, visual consistency, and privacy.
Class 3	Publish, complete the Usability Test with a classmate, fix problems, and submit the final link.

9. Connection to the Applied AI unit

This is probably the most valuable part of the idea: students first create the portfolio without AI. Later, after they have learned how to use AI tools responsibly, they can return to the same project.

Return question: “Now that you know how to use AI responsibly, how could AI improve this site?”

- Improve or summarize text without losing the student's voice.
- Review the structure and clarity of the navigation.
- Generate appropriate visual ideas.
- Review accessibility or readability.
- Compare human decisions with AI-generated suggestions.
- Document a before AI / after AI version and justify which changes they accepted and which they rejected.

Result: the first week is no longer just about “creating a template.” Students build a digital academic identity, practice organization and design, prepare their year-long portfolio, and create a project that can later be revisited to teach AI with context and purpose.

Suggested activity name

DIGITAL PASSPORT

Build Your Academic Portfolio